poster that called Amos Oz, David Grossman, and other celebrated Israeli icons “moles in culture”, suggesting that they were foreign agents. The Knesset debated one bill to bar Breaking the Silence, the anti-occupation group led by combat veterans, from speaking in Israeli schools, and another to forbid Israeli teenagers from doing their national service with liberal NGOs like B’Tselem. “It’s part of a bigger picture of nationalism—trying to beat the left and the Arabs as much as you can,” said Amir Fuchs, a researcher at the Israel Democracy Institute. “It’s populism, which is a popular thing right now, and not only in Israel.”

The Bibiton

The early elections that propelled Regev into the culture ministry happened for a number of reasons: Netanyahu’s effort to push the “Jewish state law”; aftershocks from the Gaza war; the general fragility of his coalition. But there was an additional reason, which hasn’t been mentioned yet: the so-called “*Israel HaYom* bill”.

The prime minister has a unique advantage over his Israeli rivals, or indeed most democratically-elected leaders. He has a popular newspaper in his back pocket. His first stint in office lasted only three years, and he blamed his 1999 defeat partly on the media, telling aides “I lost because I didn’t have a newspaper.” He fixed that problem before returning to office with the help of his friend and ally Sheldon Adelson, the American casino magnate, who founded *Israel HaYom* (“Israel Today”) in 2007. Adelson further expanded his media empire in 2015 with the purchase of *Makor Rishon* (“Primary Source”), a flagging conservative daily that now publishes weekly.

Israel HaYom is today the country’s most-read publication, with a weekday print run of 325,000, one copy for every twenty-five Israelis. It owes its wide exposure largely to the fact that it is free. You can grab a copy from the display outside your local corner store or coffee shop. If you don’t, a vendor might thrust one into your hands in the shopping mall—or even through your window as you sit in Tel Aviv traffic.

Adelson calls the paper a corrective, an attempt to fix a deep bias in the Israeli media. “The newspaper [sic] there was so far to the left politically that it was misleading the public,” the reclusive mogul told the *Macau Daily Times* in a rare 2015 interview.[13] (Some Israelis wonder wryly how